

Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) Declared – SPOK-24 Virus Outbreak

Situation Report – 4, published 12 November 2024 (Week 45)

Highlights

- WHO declares a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) following an emergency committee meeting.
- **A total of 287 detected cases (not requiring hospital care) of Virus SPOK-24 in Brisbane; actual numbers likely much higher due to limited testing.**
- Hospitalizations due to respiratory infections continue to increase despite a downward trend in influenza, COVID-19, and RSV.
- Contact tracing has collapsed in Brisbane, making containment efforts increasingly difficult.
- Confirmed international spread.
- CDC travel advisory escalated to Level 3 on November 6, followed by multiple countries implementing strict travel restrictions to and from Australia.
- On November 11, USA, Russia, France, Spain, Italy, Ireland, Argentina, China, Switzerland, Belgium, Portugal, New Zealand, Taiwan, and Mexico restricted travel to and from Australia for humanitarian reasons only.
- Repatriation flights are being coordinated for stranded citizens.
- Domestic travel within Australia has dropped to less than 10% as concerns grow over transmission risks.

WHO Declaration of a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC)

On November 12, the WHO Emergency Committee, after reviewing available epidemiological data, declared the ongoing Virus SPOK-24 outbreak a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC). This decision was made based on:

- ⚠ Sustained human-to-human transmission with ongoing national and international spread.
- ⚠ Increasing case numbers with limited testing capacity.
- ⚠ Significant strain on healthcare systems, particularly in Brisbane, where contact tracing has become ineffective.

- ⚠️ Growing international concern, with confirmed imported cases in multiple countries and increasing travel restrictions.
- ⚠️ Potential for severe disease outcomes, with multiple deaths including pediatric fatalities.

Under the International Health Regulations (IHR 2005), WHO urges all countries to immediately enhance surveillance, expand testing, strengthen healthcare capacity, and implement necessary travel measures to contain further spread.

CURRENT EPIDEMIOLOGICAL SITUATION			
1. Total Confirmed Hospitalizations (Negative for Common Respiratory Panels, Under Investigation for Virus SPOK-24)			
Location	Total Hospitalizations (Cumulative)	New (Week 45)	Atypical Pneumonia (%)
Brisbane Metro, QLD	200	+45	~10%
Mackay, QLD	2	+2	~10%
Townsville, QLD	12	+3	~10%
Cairns, QLD	4	+2	~10%
Rockhampton, QLD	8	+3	~10%
Sydney, NSW	31	+12	~10%
Melbourne, VIC	10	+5	~10%
Hobart, TAS	3	+2	~10%
Sunshine Coast, QLD	4	+2	~10%
Perth, WA	2	+2	~10%
TOTAL	276	+78	~10%
2. Confirmed Deaths (All Virus SPOK-24 Positive)			
Location	Total Deaths (Cumulative)	New Deaths (Week 45)	
Brisbane Metro, QLD	16	+4	
Sydney, NSW	1	+1	
Cairns, QLD	2	+1	
Sunshine Coast, QLD	3	+1	
Melbourne, VIC	2	+1	
TOTAL	24	+8	
3. New Confirmed Importation of Virus SPOK-24 disease cases from Australia			
- Wellington, NZL (Nov 4), Auckland, NZL (Nov 10), Christchurch, NZL (Nov 5). - Amman, Jordan (Nov 6).			

- Qingdao, CHN (Nov 10), Chengdu, CHN (Nov 4, Nov 5), Hong Kong, CHN (Nov 3).
- Port Moresby, PNG (Nov 6).
- Phuket, Thailand (Nov 2).
- Madrid, Spain (Nov 8).
- Denpasar, Indonesia (Nov 9).
- Dublin, Ireland (Nov 4).
- San Francisco, USA (Nov 7).
- Singapore (Nov 6).
- Dubai, UAE (Nov 3, Nov 6).
- Athens, Greece (Nov 3).
- Cairo, Egypt (Nov 5).
- Tokyo, Japan (Nov 9).

Fictional Training Use Only